

SUNRISERS ECLIPSED BY RUTHLESS KNIGHT RIDERS

Kolkata Knight Riders' dominant eight-wicket victory over Sunrisers Hyderabad in the IPL final highlighted the **increasing significance of bowling prowess** in a batter-friendly format.

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There is an overwhelming sense of emptiness when an event that many feverishly awaited ends. This sentiment was even more pronounced at the end of this year's Indian Premier League (IPL).

After matching each other stroke for stroke to become two of the league's fastest-scoring teams, Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR) and Sunrisers Hyderabad (SRH) delivered the most lopsided final in the tournament's history.

KKR galloped to an eight-wicket win, overcoming SRH's 113 inside 11 overs to end the contest almost an hour ahead of schedule. Pat Cummins' trophy-winning spree on the international circuit had finally been curtailed by the crash-bang-wallop of T20 cricket's cash cow.

Perhaps the only consolation for the Australian Test and ODI skipper was that cricket's oft-quoted and overused truism — 'Batsmen win you games, bowlers win you tournaments' — had been vindicated.

That his Aussie teammate and bowling partner Mitchell Starc emerged as the most ardent proponent of that adage would have felt bittersweet.

When the left-arm pacer's classical delivery to knock the top of Abhishek Sharma's off-stump in the first over set the tone, Cummins' instinct in the longest format may have kicked in —